

Afternoon Discoveries

Monday, September 21, 2026



AMONG THE LETTERS

SEP 21, 2026



Literary Fiction & Poetry

Monday moves between stories that let pressure accumulate and poems that ask an image, an object, or a title to do more than one kind of work. Today begins with a new story about grief, family, compulsion, and an aging horse, then moves through dark comedy, childhood under war, strange acts of faith, and poetry from the newest issue of The Kenyon Review.

All links were checked against the linked magazine, publication, or literary organization page on September 21, 2026.

Featured Discovery

Dark Horse - Sarah Anderson

Grief has distorted nearly every part of the narrator's life in Anderson's new story, including her relationship with her father and with Claudia, the aging horse he refuses to let disappear quietly. When her father decides to haul Claudia hundreds of miles to a slaughterhouse near the Mexican border, the trip gathers mourning, resentment, drinking, bodily fear, and family loyalty into the same cramped space. Anderson keeps finding dark comedy inside material that could easily become solemn, and *The New Yorker* has also published her reading of the story through *The Writer's Voice*, making its control of pace and tone especially easy to hear.

Listen to and read "Dark Horse"

The Discovery Desk

An All-Consuming Love - Daniel Krieger

A couple's argument begins in the recognizable vocabulary of therapy and turns strange almost before there is time to notice. Janet has been consuming the narrator's friends, and Krieger treats that impossible fact with the conversational irritation of an ordinary relationship problem. The joke keeps working because the emotional logic underneath it remains familiar. Published by *Necessary Fiction* on September 16, this is a compact lesson in what can happen when a metaphor is taken literally and then followed without flinching.

Read "An All-Consuming Love" in *Necessary Fiction*

The Traveler's Stone - Erin Jean

Grief makes coincidence difficult to leave alone. In Erin Jean's *New Voices* story, a parent mourning the death of baby Felix attends a psychic-medium reading and comes away with a moonstone called the Traveler's Stone. From there, ordinary glitches and accidents begin to feel capable of carrying messages. The story is strongest in the uncertainty it preserves: belief can offer comfort without becoming certainty, and an object can gather emotional weight without solving what caused it.

Read "The Traveler's Stone" in *The Masters Review*

How to Hold Water **- Carlos Andrés Gómez**

The title begins with an impossible physical instruction. Water can be cupped for a moment, carried imperfectly, redirected, spilled, or lost, but never held without consequence. Gómez's poem appears in the current issue of *The Kenyon Review*, and it is worth entering through that tension between keeping and release. Read it once for its images, then again for the verbs and for every place the poem changes what "holding" might mean.

Read "How to Hold Water" in *The Kenyon Review*

Honey Bees of the Exclusion Zone **-Radha Marcum**

Marcum's title places living systems inside a landscape already burdened with human history. She is both a poet and an environmental writer, and this current-issue poem brings those attentions into the same field. It is worth reading for the way observation changes when nature cannot be separated cleanly from catastrophe, memory, or the human stories attached to a place.

Read "Honey Bees of the Exclusion Zone" in *The Kenyon Review*

Beyond this point are more stories from Necessary Fiction and The Masters Review, fiction from T. C. Boyle and Helen Simpson, more poetry from the current Kenyon Review, and three paths outward into an entire issue, a new writer profile, and this week's National Book Award longlists.

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Thank you for reading!

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Special Recommendations can be found near the bottom of the article.

Beyond the First Shelf

The Last Straw - Mark Abdon

A high-school prom invitation gives Abdon a small stage for class, humiliation, performance, and the terrifying possibility of sincerity. Eddie is a farm boy; Jessica is the cheer captain he approaches with a Ring Pop. Then straw begins appearing where it should not. The story understands how quickly adolescent cruelty can turn a gesture into spectacle, but it also leaves room for people to resist the roles everyone else has assigned them.

Read "The Last Straw" in Necessary Fiction

Lost Girls - Melissa Ostrom

Lucy, Jasmine, and Sutton each find a different way to become lost from the version of girlhood expected of them. Ostrom builds the story through separate but echoing sections, letting

social media, family judgment, self-presentation, and the desire to escape recognition press against one another. The interesting reversal is in the title: being “found” is not automatically rescue, and being lost is not always failure.

[Read “Lost Girls” in Necessary Fiction](#)

A Town of Cherry Pits - Pegah Ouj

Bomb sirens sound while Zahra and her mother make and sell cherry jam in Khorramshahr. Around them is the Iran-Iraq War; in Zahra’s hands are cherry pits and sticks that can still become the materials of an imagined town. Ouj lets the scale of war remain enormous without allowing it to erase the smaller logic of childhood. Food, play, absence, and danger occupy the same rooms, which is precisely what gives the story its force.

[Read “A Town of Cherry Pits” in The Masters Review](#)

Assemblage - Vivian Wolfson

Jane is on a date when she sees Gordon Ramsay and wonders whether he remembers her from *MasterChef Junior*. That encounter becomes an opening into a much larger question about the selves other people remember and the self that continues after they stop looking. Wolfson’s story moves through Jane’s interior life in an unusually compressed form, making the title feel like a description of both the narrative method and the person being assembled inside it.

[Read "Assemblage" in The Masters Review](#)

The Brothers - Clare Fielder

This honorable mention from *The Masters Review's* Winter Short Story Award enters an old monastic world through a brother consumed by the desire to catalogue and illuminate every animal in creation. Devotion gradually becomes obsession, and an undertaking meant to honor God begins testing the body, the community, and the bond between brothers. The second-person narration makes the spiritual and personal pressure unusually intimate.

[Read "The Brothers" in The Masters Review](#)

The Enemy - Joan Larkin

A title this direct seems to promise a boundary: someone belongs on one side, someone on the other. Larkin's story is a good place to pay attention to the instability of that act of naming. Watch who is permitted to define the enemy, what the word makes possible, and whether it remains attached to the same person or idea by the end.

[Read "The Enemy" in The Kenyon Review](#)

What the Photos Didn't Reveal **- T. C. Boyle**

Photographs recovered after a sheriff's investigation appear to offer evidence about a vanished family, but evidence is never the same thing as a story. Boyle's narrator immediately begins imagining how the disappearance might be shaped into one, turning images, news, speculation, and ambition over against one another. The title points directly at the problem: a photograph can show something happened while remaining silent about what it means.

Read "What the Photos Didn't Reveal" in [The Kenyon Review](#)

Lub Dub Lub Dub Lub Dub **- Helen Simpson**

Two old friends meet for coffee before one heads off to visit her ninety-two-year-old mother. Their conversation moves easily from stovetops and pacemakers to aging husbands, elderly parents, cardiac arrests, and the uncomfortable knowledge that bodies eventually refuse every plan made for them. Simpson keeps mortality inside ordinary talk rather than announcing it from above. The repeated heartbeat of the title becomes harder to ignore as the conversation continues.

The New Yorker also offers Simpson's own audio reading.

Read and listen to "Lub Dub Lub Dub Lub Dub"

Poetry Shelf

3 a.m. **- Radha Marcum**

The hour arrives with its own emotional weather. Scale changes at three in the morning: small sounds become intrusive, ordinary worries become enormous, and thoughts that daylight can organize no longer behave. Read Marcum's poem alongside "Honey Bees of the Exclusion Zone" and notice what remains consistent when her attention moves from a charged landscape to an equally charged hour.

Read "3 a.m." in [The Kenyon Review](#)

TruthFinder1982 **- Kai Carlson-Wee**

The title sounds simultaneously like a username, a search service, and a promise no person could comfortably keep. That collision between digital naming and the older human desire to know what really happened gives the poem an intriguing threshold. Pay attention to where information ends and memory, interpretation, or invention has to begin.

Read "TruthFinder1982" in [The Kenyon Review](#)

Record of First Love **- Alison Clara Tan**

“Record” can be evidence, memory, documentation, an account made after the fact, or something preserved because the original moment cannot be kept. Tan’s poem begins with that useful ambiguity already built into its title. Read for the distance between first experience and later recollection, and for what changes when emotion becomes something the speaker can examine.

Read “Record of First Love” in [The Kenyon Review](#)

The Swan, No. 12 **- Victoria Chang**

Chang’s poem is written after Hilma af Klint, whose paintings repeatedly give abstract form to questions that resist ordinary explanation. Here, geometry, beauty, knowledge, time, and the act of looking begin to overlap. The numbered title matters too: this is not “the” swan but one swan inside a sequence, which turns a familiar lyric image into something observed, repeated, classified, and reconsidered.

Read “The Swan, No. 12” in [The Kenyon Review](#)

Special Recommendations

Read Across One Issue **- The Kenyon Review, Vol. XLVIII No. 1**

Several of today's selections come from the newest issue of *The Kenyon Review*, but the better reason to open the table of contents is everything around them. The issue brings fiction, poetry, nonfiction, reviews, an Invisible Cities folio, and the winning work from the magazine's 2025 Nonfiction Contest into the same space. Pick one title that immediately attracts you and one you would normally pass over. A magazine's editorial character often becomes clearest in the distance between those choices.

[Explore the current issue of The Kenyon Review](#)

Read Around a Writer **- Barbara Kingsolver**

A new *New Yorker* profile of Barbara Kingsolver looks at the beliefs beneath a long career in fiction: what novels can do, where social purpose belongs inside art, how place enters the work, and why literary seriousness need not require distance from ordinary readers. The profile arrives ahead of her October novel *Partita* and is most useful as a route back into the fiction rather than a substitute for it.

[Read "What Barbara Kingsolver Believes the Novel Can Do"](#)

Read the Longlists - 2026 National Book Awards

The National Book Foundation has now announced its 2026 Fiction and Poetry longlists, with ten books in each category. Finalists will be announced on October 6. This is a particularly good moment to browse because attention has not yet narrowed to five names, much less one winner. The Fiction list includes two debut novels; the Poetry list ranges across independent, university, and major presses. Victoria Chang, whose poem appears above, is among this year's Poetry longlisted for *Tree of Knowledge*.

[Explore the 2026 Fiction Longlist](#)

[Explore the 2026 Poetry Longlist](#)

Thank you for reading and subscribing. Your support gives this publication the time to read beyond the loudest releases, check the important details, and keep looking for work that might otherwise be missed.

I hope one of today's pieces gives you a sentence to revisit, a writer to follow, or a magazine to spend some time among the letters with.

Take care!